According to Orlov, the order to prepare the nuclear-armed torpedo was rescinded after Savitsky calmed down and discussed the situation with Arkhipov and the political officer, Maslennikov. The three of them decided to bring the submarine to the surface. Orlov's story about Savitsky's order to make the torpedo combat-ready gained currency in the literature on the Cuban missile crisis in the early 2000s and served as the basis for numerous academic and popular accounts about the B-59's ordeal. They also helped to burnish the image of Vasilii Arkhipov as the man who saved the world from nuclear catastrophe by dissuading Savitsky from firing an atomic weapon. This turned out to be just one of many accounts. The recollections of other officers on board the B-59 that have appeared subsequently paint a somewhat different though no less dramatic picture of what happened beneath the surface of the Sargasso Sea during those fateful hours and minutes of October 27.

The sub's navigator, Viktor Mikhailov, and the officer responsible for the torpedo launchers, Anatoly Leonenko, agree that the decision to surface was prompted not by the American practice charges and grenades, which the vessel could withstand, but by the simple fact that its batteries had run down and it could no longer remain underwater. According to the same accounts, however, Savitsky indeed gave the order to prepare the atomic torpedo for firing and only then agreed to have the vessel surface. Leonenko recalls that Savitsky ordered him to get the torpedoes in the seventh stern compartment of the submarine ready to fire.

"Prepare the equipment for firing!" ordered Leonenko on reaching the stern compartment, but his order was met with bewilderment by his subordinates. "The commander of the torpedo group, Senior Lieutenant V. Liashetsky, stood mutely rooted to the spot, a look of astonishment in his eyes," recalled Leonenko. "After a brief pause the commander of the torpedo unit, Petty Officer Second Class Kalita, told me that war had broken out and that we ought to be at home; our fiancées were waiting for us." Leonenko was faced with something close to insubordination. He used every term of abuse he could think of, and the lieutenant and petty officer fell into line. Leonenko reported to Savitsky that his order had been carried out. They began to surface.[17]